THREADS of LIGHT

STORIES • LEARNING • SERVICE
ACROSS THE CLUSTERS

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OUR INAUGURAL ISSUE

A Community Connected Through Service

UNIT CONVENTION • ḤUQÚQU'LLÁH • QUDRAT • VIRTUES • HIDDEN WORDS

An independent, Bahá'í inspired publication

ISSUE 01

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A LETTER TO OUR READERS

From the Editor

A beginning inspired by consultation, sustained by hope, and dedicated to the light we discover in one another.

> *"Sometimes a small ember carried from one place to another can kindle something new. Perhaps the same is true of the stories we share, the lessons we learn, and the light we offer one another."*

Dear Friends,

Alláh'u'Abhá!

It is with a heart full of gratitude, hope, and loving anticipation that I welcome you to the inaugural issue of Threads of Light.

There is something profoundly beautiful about the way a single thought, offered sincerely and perhaps without any expectation of what might follow, can become the beginning of something much greater. A few words spoken during consultation may remain with us long after a gathering has ended. A simple observation may awaken a question. A question may become a prayer. And sometimes, through prayer, reflection, and a willingness to act, the smallest seed of an idea begins to take root.

Threads of Light began in just such a way.

At our recent Bahá'í Unit Convention, as friends gathered in fellowship and consultation, a thoughtful observation was shared. How much do we truly know about the activities, initiatives, challenges, and accomplishments unfolding throughout our neighboring communities? How often do we discover, almost by chance, that friends just a few miles away have been engaged in meaningful efforts from which we might have learned, drawn encouragement, or offered support?

The question stayed with me.

Even after Convention had concluded and we had returned to our daily lives, I found myself reflecting on the many experiences that must be taking place beyond our immediate circles of friendship. During my prayers, the thought returned with greater urgency and possibility: Why should we wait until the next annual gathering to discover what has been happening among us?

Could we not find a way to share these experiences while they are still unfolding, allowing their lessons, encouragement, and inspiration to travel from one community to another?

From that reflection, ***Threads of Light*** was born.

The vision is simple, yet I believe its possibilities are meaningful.

Throughout our communities, countless expressions of faith, kindness, perseverance, generosity, and service take place every day. Some are visible through organized activities, devotional gatherings, children's classes, junior youth groups, study circles, and collective endeavors. Others unfold quietly, far from public attention, through a conversation with a neighbor, an unexpected act of compassion, a friendship patiently nurtured, or the willingness of one individual to offer assistance when it is needed most.

Not every meaningful contribution produces a measurable result. Not every sincere effort unfolds as anticipated. Sometimes an invitation is declined, a gathering attracts only a few participants, or a carefully considered approach reveals an unexpected challenge. Yet even these experiences may contain valuable lessons. What was learned? What might be approached differently? What encouragement emerged? What might another friend discover through hearing about the experience?

I believe there is great spiritual value in recognizing these moments, not simply for what they accomplish, but for what they teach us about service, humility, perseverance, reliance upon God, and the gradual transformation of ourselves and our communities.

A LETTER TO OUR READERS (continued)

This is what I hope ***Threads of Light*** will help illuminate.

Our purpose is not to celebrate accomplishments alone, nor to create another collection of announcements and activity reports. Rather, it is to make the learning contained within community life more visible and accessible, to recognize the often unseen efforts of individuals and groups, and to provide a space where experiences can be shared with sincerity, dignity, and an openness to learning.



Imagine a friend in Claremont discovering an approach to neighborhood engagement that has brought unexpected joy to a family in San Bernardino. Imagine a children's class in Upland inspiring a similar effort in Victorville. Imagine someone who has quietly struggled to sustain a devotional gathering finding renewed courage through another person's account of patience and perseverance. And imagine an individual who has never considered their own modest efforts worthy of mention discovering that their experience has given someone else the confidence to begin.

Such possibilities remind us that the significance of an act of service cannot always be measured by its immediate visibility or apparent success. A gesture that seems small to the person offering it may carry extraordinary meaning for the person receiving it. Through ***Threads of Light***, I hope we may begin to recognize more of these connections.

Our initial focus will be the friends and communities throughout the clusters represented within our Unit, while warmly welcoming experiences and contributions from neighboring communities and beyond whenever their insights may enrich our collective learning, strengthen our bonds of fellowship, or offer meaningful encouragement in the advancement of the Cause. Our hope is to create a publication that celebrates the richness of our shared spiritual life, honors the distinctive experiences and contributions of each community, and allows the lessons of service, faith, and perseverance to travel wherever they may be of benefit.

Each Bahá'í month, alongside community news and personal experiences, we envision opportunities to explore the Sacred Writings, reflect upon the spiritual significance of the month, examine one of the Hidden Words, consider the practical expression of a virtue, and deepen our understanding of principles that guide our individual and collective lives. We also hope to share reflections connected to the Nine Year Plan, the institution of Huqúqu'lláh, and other subjects that may help illuminate the relationship between spiritual understanding and purposeful action.

These features are intended not merely to inform, but to invite reflection. What do the teachings ask of us? How might their wisdom shape our relationships, our choices, and our service? How can spiritual principles become increasingly visible in the ordinary circumstances of everyday life?

Our inaugural issue begins, fittingly, with the gathering that inspired this initiative. We reflect upon our recent Unit Convention, the significance of consultation and participation, and the creative expressions of generosity and service that helped make the occasion meaningful. We also remember Thornton Chase, whose life and example continue to inspire the friends, and share a deeply thoughtful personal experience offered by one of our first contributors.

These stories are different in subject and circumstance, yet they share a common thread: the possibility that faith, expressed through action and sustained by love, can touch lives in ways we may never fully anticipate.

As this publication begins, I am deeply conscious that its value will not be determined by the beauty of its pages or the number of stories it contains. Its true value, if we are fortunate enough to realize it, will lie in the connections it helps strengthen, the encouragement it offers, the understanding it deepens, and the service it may inspire.

A LETTER TO OUR READERS (continued)

For this reason, ***Threads of Light*** must remain a shared endeavor in spirit, even as it is independently developed and administered. Its growth will depend upon the generosity of those willing to contribute their experiences, the openness of those willing to learn from them, and the loving participation of friends who recognize that every community has something meaningful to offer.

No contribution is too modest simply because it lacks grandeur. No experience is without value merely because its outcome was different from what was hoped. And no one should feel that they must possess exceptional eloquence, expertise, or accomplishments before their voice deserves to be heard.

We are not seeking perfection. We are seeking sincerity, understanding, learning, and the opportunity to encourage one another.

We begin with a pilot spanning six Bahá'í months, with the hope that this initiative will evolve through feedback, consultation, and the experiences shared by the friends. We welcome suggestions, constructive criticism, stories, reflections, and new ideas. What proves useful may grow. What does not serve the friends may be reconsidered. The publication should remain responsive to the communities it hopes to serve.

Above all, I pray that this undertaking may be guided by pure intentions, humility, wisdom, and a genuine spirit of service. May it never become an exercise in recognition for its own sake, but rather a means of appreciating the contributions of others, deepening our bonds of friendship, and drawing inspiration from the teachings of Bahá'u'lláh as we strive, however imperfectly, to put them into practice.

If even one person finds renewed encouragement through a story shared here, if one community discovers an idea that strengthens its efforts, if one quiet act of service receives the appreciation it deserves, or if one reader feels moved to offer a little more kindness, patience, courage, or love, then this endeavor will already have begun to fulfill its purpose.

To the friends who have offered encouragement, shared their thoughts, expressed interest, or entrusted us with their experiences, thank you. Your kindness has given this beginning a warmth and meaning that I could not have anticipated.

And to those encountering ***Threads of Light*** for the first time, welcome. I hope you will find within these pages something that speaks to your heart, nourishes your spirit, and reminds you of the extraordinary possibilities that can emerge when ordinary people choose to serve with love.

May we learn to recognize the light in one another, celebrate it without reservation, and carry its warmth beyond the boundaries of our own communities.

May the stories we share become threads of friendship, understanding, encouragement, and service, woven together into something far more beautiful than any one of us could create alone.

And may every sincere effort, however small, become another means through which the light of God's love may reach the hearts of His children.

With loving Bahá'í greetings, heartfelt gratitude, and warmest appreciation,

Azadeh
Editor, Threads of Light
Stories • Learning • Service Across the Clusters

COMMUNITY LIFE

Gathering in a Spirit of Unity

Unit Convention | Hughes Community Center | October 4, 2026



Friends from across the electoral Unit gather at Hughes Community Center in Claremont on October 4, 2026, for the annual Bahá'í Unit Convention, an occasion for consultation, fellowship, and the election of a delegate to the National Convention. Photograph courtesy of Azadeh

On October 4, 2026, friends from across the electoral Unit gathered at Hughes Community Center in Claremont, California, for the annual Bahá'í Unit Convention, hosted this year by the Local Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Claremont. The occasion was at once deeply spiritual, purposeful, and warmly familiar, bringing together friends across generations for consultation, fellowship, and the sacred responsibility of electing a delegate to the National Convention.

Around tables adorned with autumn flowers, friends of different ages, backgrounds, and communities came together in a spirit of fellowship and shared responsibility. The gathering brought together generations, from a child just eighteen months old to elders in their nineties, each contributing to the rich tapestry of community life simply through their presence. There were warm greetings, familiar embraces, introductions between new acquaintances, conversations over shared food, and laughter among friends. Some had known one another for decades. Others were discovering connections with people from neighboring communities whose paths they might otherwise seldom cross. The atmosphere reflected something precious about Bahá'í community life: the opportunity to find unity not in sameness, but in the diversity of experiences, ages, perspectives, and contributions brought together through a common love for Bahá'u'lláh and a shared desire to serve humanity.

Yet beneath the warmth of the occasion lay a profound responsibility.

A Sacred Responsibility, a Collective Voice

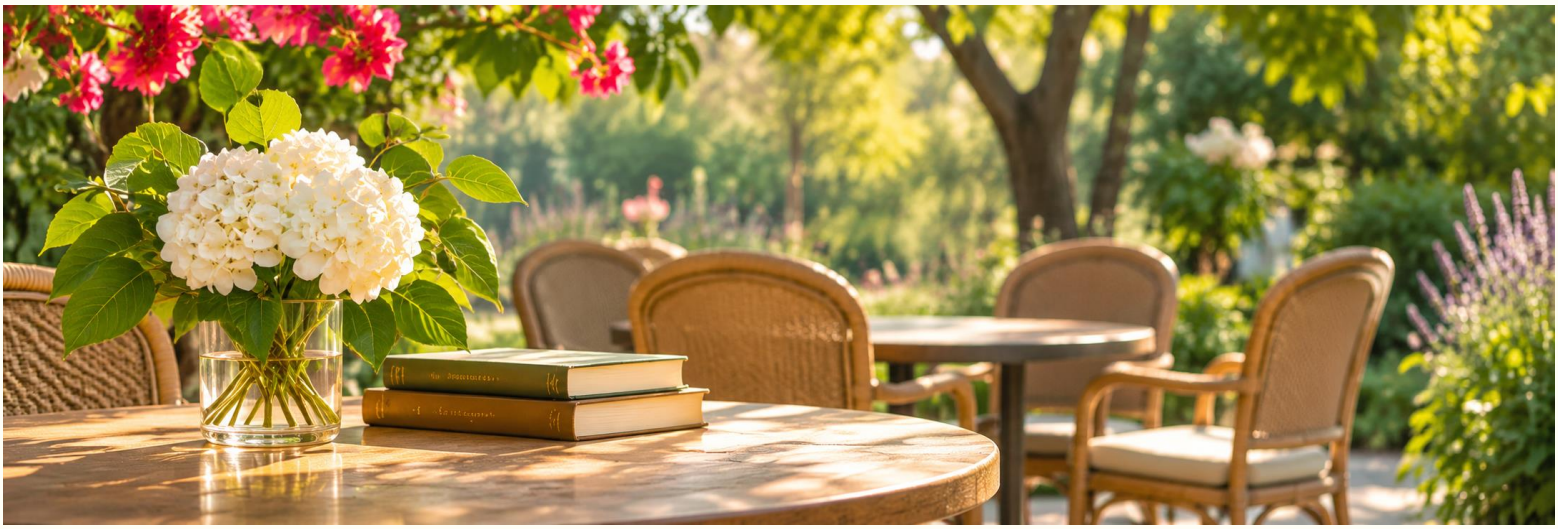
Unit Convention occupies a distinctive place in the Bahá'í Administrative Order. Each year, eligible adult Bahá'ís participate in electing delegates who will attend the National Bahá'í Convention in Wilmette, Illinois, where they will consult on the affairs and progress of the Faith and elect the nine members of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of the United States.

Unlike conventional electoral systems, Bahá'í elections are conducted without nominations, political campaigns, or electioneering. The process calls upon individuals to approach their responsibility prayerfully, independently, and with careful consideration of the spiritual qualities and capacities required for service.

The significance of this process extends far beyond the casting of a ballot. It reflects a fundamental principle of Bahá'í administration: that authority is exercised through institutions whose members are chosen without personal campaigning, and whose responsibilities are understood in terms of service rather than privilege.

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Convention also provides an opportunity for consultation, allowing friends from different communities to share observations, examine challenges, celebrate progress, and consider how their collective efforts might better contribute to the advancement of the Cause.



A Sacred Trust, A Delegate Elected

At the heart of the gathering was the sacred responsibility entrusted to the friends of Electoral Unit 132: the election of a delegate who would represent them at the forthcoming National Bahá'í Convention in April 2027, where delegates from across the country will participate in the election of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of the United States.

Following the election, the Local Spiritual Assembly of Claremont announced that Soheila Azizi had been elected as the delegate for Electoral Unit 132.

In expressing her gratitude for the trust placed in her, Soheila warmly encouraged the friends to join her when she shares her report following the National Convention, whether in person or through Zoom. She expressed her intention to offer the community a personal window into the experience, its spirit, its deliberations, and the fellowship that characterizes this important national gathering.

Her election marked not simply the conclusion of a voting process, but the beginning of a responsibility carried forward on behalf of the friends throughout the Unit. The gathering in Claremont would conclude that afternoon, but its purpose would extend beyond the walls of Hughes Community Center, continuing through the participation of their elected delegate in the national life of the Faith.

Many Communities, One Shared Purpose

Throughout the gathering, the spirit of consultation was complemented by the simple but meaningful joys of being together.

Friends listened to presentations, reflected upon the development of community life, and shared experiences from their respective areas. Conversations continued around the tables, where food and fellowship provided opportunities to renew friendships and form new ones.

The gathering offered a visible reminder that a community is strengthened not only through formal activities and institutional arrangements, but also through the countless gestures of kindness, patience, encouragement, and cooperation that sustain relationships.

A helping hand offered without hesitation, a conversation that welcomed someone into a circle of friends, an experience shared with sincerity, or an encouraging word offered to someone facing a challenge: these ordinary expressions of fellowship help create the conditions in which collective service can flourish.

The presence of children, youth, adults, and elders also reflected the continuity of a community whose future is nurtured through the participation of successive generations. While the youngest attendees may not yet understand the

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administrative significance of Convention, their presence alongside those who have devoted decades to the Faith offered a moving illustration of the community's enduring life.

From Consultation to Action

Among the subjects explored during Convention were the efforts taking place throughout the communities of the Unit, the experiences emerging from service, and the ongoing process of learning how to contribute more effectively to the spiritual and material progress of society.

Such conversations carry particular significance during the Nine Year Plan, which invites Bahá'í communities throughout the world to strengthen patterns of community life, expand participation, and learn through sustained action and reflection.

The experiences shared during Convention demonstrated that meaningful progress is not confined to large undertakings or highly visible accomplishments. It may emerge through the patient efforts of friends accompanying one another, through children's classes and junior youth activities, through devotional gatherings, through conversations that build understanding and simple acts of service offered with sincerity.

Each community has its own circumstances, capacities, challenges, and opportunities. Yet the lessons learned in one place may prove valuable in another. An approach that strengthens participation in one neighborhood may inspire a similar effort elsewhere. A challenge overcome through consultation may offer encouragement to friends facing comparable circumstances.

And sometimes, simply discovering that others are engaged in the same process of learning and service can renew one's own sense of purpose.

The Connections That Continue Beyond Convention

Perhaps one of the most meaningful reflections to emerge from the gathering concerned the very nature of these connections.

As the gathering concluded, the significance of Convention extended beyond the election and the consultations that had taken place. It remained in the friendships renewed, the insights exchanged, the encouragement received, and the possibilities that friends carried home.

For while Convention brings us together for a particular purpose on a particular day, the spirit of unity it fosters need not end when the gathering concludes.

It can continue through our conversations, our prayers, our willingness to accompany one another, and our determination to translate spiritual principles into meaningful action.

And perhaps that is among the most beautiful possibilities of gathering in consultation and fellowship: that we may leave not only better informed about the efforts of others, but more deeply conscious of the responsibility and privilege we share in contributing to the advancement of our communities.

The gathering may last only a day. The friendships, insights, and acts of service it inspires may continue bearing fruit long afterward.



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The Bountiful Bookstand

When Books Find New Homes, Their Stories Continue



What began as a creative act of generosity at Unit Convention in Claremont became an opportunity to share knowledge, support the Fund, preserve treasured memories, and open the possibility for books to continue serving readers far beyond the community where their journey began.

There is something extraordinary about a book that has already been loved.

Its pages may have been turned countless times in moments of prayer, study, reflection, or uncertainty. Its margins may hold the quiet evidence of a reader's discoveries. An inscription inside its cover may preserve a mother's love for her son. A small stamp may testify to a journey across oceans, to a sacred place where countless hearts have turned in devotion.

And sometimes, after years of faithful companionship, that same book finds its way into another pair of hands, beginning a new chapter in a story whose ending no one can foresee.

At the October 4, 2026, Bahá'í Unit Convention, held at the Alexander Hughes Community Center in Claremont and hosted by the Local Spiritual Assembly of Claremont, one particularly meaningful initiative offered a beautiful illustration of this possibility. It was called the **Bountiful Bookstand**.

A Different Kind of Bookstand

For many Bahá'ís, a bookstand is a familiar and welcome feature of community gatherings. It offers opportunities to discover the Sacred Writings, explore the history of the Faith, deepen one's understanding of spiritual principles, and find materials to support individual and collective study.

Yet even the most thoughtfully stocked traditional bookstand is necessarily limited by the titles available, the cost of purchasing new publications, and the practical considerations of transporting and displaying them.

The Bountiful Bookstand introduced a different possibility.

Coordinated by Ramin Yavrom, the initiative invited previously loved Bahá'í books and other educational materials to find new readers within the community. Volumes that had rested for years on private bookshelves could once again become instruments of learning. Collections accumulated over decades could become accessible to friends who might never otherwise encounter them. Although the books were offered without a required payment, friends also had the opportunity to make voluntary contributions to the Fund. A contribution box placed near the books provided a simple way for those who wished to give.

What emerged was more than a creative alternative to the traditional bookstand. It was an opportunity for generosity to take several forms at once.

Those who contributed books offered the accumulated treasures of their personal libraries. Those who received them gained access to writings, histories, reflections, and educational materials that might enrich their lives. And those who chose to make financial contributions extended the benefit still further by supporting the collective endeavors of the Faith.

The same act could therefore become an expression of giving, receiving, learning, and service.

More Than Books: A Treasury of Human Connections

Among the materials that found new homes were prayer books, sacred texts, poetry, and recorded lectures. Yet some of the most remarkable discoveries were not immediately visible on the covers or spines.

They were waiting inside.

One prayer book carried a personal inscription from a mother to her son. Its new recipient did not discover the

COMMUNITY LIFE

The Bountiful Bookstand

When Books Find New Homes, Their Stories Continue

inscription until returning home.

What might otherwise have been regarded simply as another volume of prayers suddenly revealed a more intimate history. Before arriving in a new home, this book had been an expression of a mother's love, a gift chosen for someone precious to her.

There is something deeply moving about such a discovery.

The words of prayer within the book remain available to every reader, yet the inscription preserves a particular moment of tenderness between two people. That affection becomes part of the book's continuing story, even as its prayers are read by someone new.

Another small prayer book bore a stamp from the Holy Land. That modest mark carried extraordinary significance. It spoke of a journey to a place sacred to Bahá'ís throughout the world, a place associated with pilgrimage, remembrance, devotion, and the spiritual history of the Faith.

The book's new custodian chose to give it to her beloved mother, placing it on the table before her photograph, alongside her prayer books used for devotionals, prayers, and Feasts. It became another cherished expression of the love and spiritual connection that continue beyond this earthly life, and a tender reminder of her enduring spiritual presence.

In this way, a book that had once traveled to the Holy Land became part of another deeply personal expression of love and remembrance.

Elsewhere, a beautifully bound copy of the *Kitáb-i-Aqdas* found a new home, while recordings of lectures by the distinguished Bahá'í scholar Adib Taherzadeh offered another listener the opportunity to encounter his explanations of the history and teachings of the Faith.

Poetry, too, found new readers.

Each item carried its own possibilities. A volume of Sacred Writings might accompany a family through years of study. A recording might illuminate a question that had remained unanswered. A poem might give language to a feeling that someone had struggled to express.

And a children's book, once enjoyed by a young reader, might someday be opened by another child beginning the same journey of discovery.

Perhaps that child will grow into a junior youth animator, a children's class teacher, or someone whose life of service was quietly influenced by the stories encountered years earlier. We cannot know. But that is precisely what makes the possibilities so beautiful.

The influence of a book is rarely confined to the person who first purchases it, the household where it first resides, or even the generation in which it is written. Knowledge has a remarkable capacity to multiply through being shared.

Generosity That Continues Beyond the Gathering



The Bountiful Bookstand's significance did not end when Convention concluded.

According to correspondence dated October 6, 2026, Bahá'í Booksource International in Los Angeles warmly welcomed the remaining books. The organization explained that suitable volumes would be considered for its bookstore inventory, while others could be included in a shipment destined for the library of the planned national Bahá'í House of Worship in the Philippines.

The Universal House of Justice announced plans for this House of Worship in April 2025, marking an important development in the spiritual life of the Bahá'í community in the Philippines.

Thus, an initiative that began in Claremont opened the possibility of continued service through readers in Los Angeles and, potentially, in the Philippines.

The books' final destinations remain to be confirmed, but the generosity that began at Unit Convention has already opened a remarkable path for their continued service.

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The Bountiful Bookstand

When Books Find New Homes, Their Stories Continue

Imagine a book that once occupied a shelf in a Southern California home eventually becoming part of a collection available to readers thousands of miles away.

Imagine a passage underlined decades earlier by one believer becoming a source of insight for another person living on the opposite side of the Pacific.

Imagine a volume that its original owner no longer needed becoming exactly the resource another reader had been searching for.

The generosity of the original contribution would remain, even as the circumstances, readers, and communities changed.

What began as an opportunity to share books within a Unit could become part of a much wider circulation of knowledge and inspiration.

The Quiet Power of Passing Something On

The beauty of the Bountiful Bookstand lies partly in its simplicity.

It did not require the creation of an entirely new body of knowledge. It invited the friends to recognize the value already present in their homes and consider how that value might be shared.

A bookshelf can be a private treasury, but it can also become the beginning of a public benefit.

The initiative suggests an approach to community life in which resources are not measured solely by their monetary value, but also by their capacity to serve.

A book that has been read many times has not exhausted its usefulness. A recording that has inspired one listener may inspire another. A cherished collection need not remain inaccessible simply because its original owner has completed a particular course of study.

And when the sharing of those resources also creates an opportunity to contribute to the Fund, the benefits extend beyond the objects themselves. The books continue their journeys, while the spirit of generosity supports other endeavors of the community.

It is a compelling reminder that service need not always begin with something new. Sometimes it begins by looking at what we already possess and asking how it might benefit someone else.

A Journey Whose Final Chapter Has Yet to Be Written

As the friends departed Convention and the tables were cleared, the Bountiful Bookstand had already accomplished something meaningful.

Books had found new homes. Personal collections had become shared resources. Opportunities for contributions to the Fund had accompanied the exchange. And the remaining materials had been offered a path toward further circulation.

Yet perhaps the most significant outcomes are those that cannot be counted.

How many prayers will be read from these books in the years ahead?

How many questions will find answers within their pages?

How many conversations will begin because someone discovers a passage worth sharing?

How many children will encounter stories that shape their understanding of kindness, courage, justice, and service?

How many hearts will be comforted by words that have already comforted others?

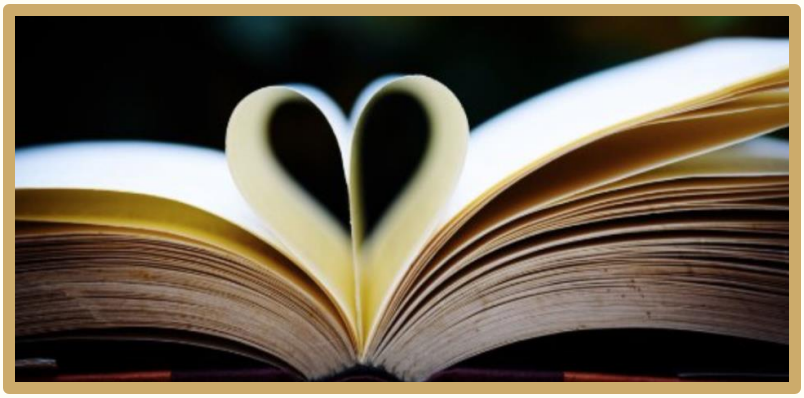
We may never know the answers.

A mother once gave a prayer book to her son. A pilgrim's journey left its mark on a small volume. A scholar's recorded words found another listener. A sacred text entered another household.

And somewhere beyond the gathering where these books changed hands, their influence continues.

The Bountiful Bookstand reminds us that the generosity of a single act can outlive the moment in which it is offered.

For a book's greatest value may not be found in the number of years it has rested on a shelf, but in the number of hearts it may yet illuminate.



REMEMBRANCE & COMMUNITY LIFE

Beneath the Tree, a Legacy of Faith

Honoring Thornton Chase, the First American Bahá'í, through prayer, music, remembrance, and fellowship at Inglewood Park Cemetery



The resting place of Thornton Chase at Inglewood Park Cemetery, where friends gathered on October 18, 2026, to honor the first American Bahá'í and the enduring legacy of his service.

Some places invite us to remember. Others invite us to reflect upon what remembrance asks of us.



Beneath the spreading branches of a magnificent tree at Inglewood Park Cemetery, friends gathered to honor a man whose spiritual journey helped lay the foundations of the Bahá'í Faith in America. Sunlight filtered through the leaves, illuminating the grounds where generations of visitors have come to pay their respects to Thornton Chase, remembered as the first American Bahá'í.

The gathering, hosted by the Local Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Los Angeles, brought together individuals and families for an afternoon of prayer, artistic expression, music, reflection, and fellowship. Yet the significance of the occasion extended beyond the commemoration of a remarkable life. It offered an opportunity to consider how one person's response to the call of faith can continue to influence hearts and communities long after that person's earthly journey has ended.

A Life That Helped Illuminate a Continent

Born in 1847, Thornton Chase lived through a period of extraordinary social, intellectual, and religious change in the United States. A Civil War veteran, businessman, writer, and spiritual seeker, Chase spent much of his life searching for religious truth and a deeper understanding of humanity's relationship with God.

In 1894, he embraced the teachings of Bahá'u'lláh, becoming recognized as the first American Bahá'í.

His acceptance of the Faith marked the beginning of a life increasingly devoted to its teachings and service. Chase helped nurture the emerging Bahá'í community in the United States, supported its early institutions, corresponded with fellow believers, and contributed to the understanding and dissemination of the Faith through his writings and personal example.

Among his notable works were *The Bahai Revelation* and *In Galilee*, which reflected both his intellectual engagement with the teachings and his spiritual devotion.

Yet perhaps his greatest legacy was not simply what he wrote or helped establish. It was the sincerity with which he sought to translate belief into action.

To embrace a new religious revelation in an environment where its teachings were largely unfamiliar required conviction, courage, and a willingness to venture beyond the boundaries of established thought. Chase's life reminds us that the growth of a spiritual community often begins with individuals whose faithfulness is expressed through patient, sustained, and frequently unheralded effort.

A Remembrance Encouraged by 'Abdu'l-Bahá



Thornton Chase passed away on September 30, 1912, while 'Abdu'l-Bahá was visiting North America.

The significance of Chase's life was affirmed in a particularly moving manner when 'Abdu'l-Bahá visited his grave in Inglewood Park Cemetery during His historic journey through the United States.

There, He offered prayers and paid tribute to the devotion of this early believer, whose steadfastness had contributed to the establishment of the Faith in America.

REMEMBRANCE & COMMUNITY LIFE

Beneath the Tree, a Legacy of Faith

Honoring Thornton Chase, the First American Bahá'í, through prayer, music, remembrance, and fellowship at Inglewood Park Cemetery

'Abdu'l-Bahá's affection for Chase and His encouragement that the friends remember him gave the annual commemoration a significance beyond an ordinary memorial observance.

The friends who gather at his resting place are participating in a tradition rooted in gratitude, remembrance, and the recognition of a life devoted to the Cause of God.

Such remembrance is not intended merely to preserve the past. It also invites each succeeding generation to consider what it means to serve faithfully in its own time.

The circumstances confronting Thornton Chase were different from those of the Bahá'í community today. Yet the qualities that sustained his service remain profoundly relevant: sincerity, steadfastness, courage, humility, love for humanity, and confidence in the transforming power of divine guidance.

An Afternoon of Prayer and Artistic Expression

Against this historical and spiritual background, the Los Angeles Bahá'í community welcomed friends to the cemetery for a program honoring Chase's life and legacy.

The memorial setting was striking in its simplicity and natural beauty.

A large tree spread its branches above the gathering, providing shade for the performers and those assembled. Nearby stood a framed portrait of Thornton Chase, a quiet reminder of the individual whose life had brought everyone together. Beyond the gathering, the cemetery's monuments and green lawns extended beneath the California sunshine.

The program began with prayers offered by participants, establishing a devotional atmosphere and inviting those present to turn their thoughts toward the spiritual significance of the occasion.

As different voices contributed to the prayers, the gathering became an expression of a central principle of Bahá'í community life: that worship and remembrance are enriched through the participation of many, rather than belonging to any single individual.



The program also included a presentation by young participants associated with the Children's Theater Company, an organization whose educational work seeks to cultivate empathy, ethical awareness, inclusivity, and social responsibility through the performing arts.

The Company's philosophy recognizes children and youth not merely as recipients of education, but as individuals capable of contributing meaningfully to the betterment of society.

Under the artistic leadership of founder Mehr Mansuri, the organization has developed programs combining music, theater, movement, and moral education. Its work reflects the belief that artistic expression can become a means of nurturing character, strengthening communities, and encouraging young people to recognize their capacity for positive change.

At the memorial, the young performers stood together beneath the great tree, contributing their own artistic expression to an occasion devoted to remembering one of the earliest believers in America.

There was something particularly meaningful in this meeting of generations.

Thornton Chase belonged to the earliest chapter of American Bahá'í history. More than a century later, children and youth were gathered near his resting place, participating in the living community that his generation had helped establish.

The contrast was a powerful reminder that a spiritual legacy is not confined to books, monuments, or historical accounts. It continues through the lives and efforts of those who come afterward.

REMEMBRANCE & COMMUNITY LIFE

Beneath the Tree, a Legacy of Faith

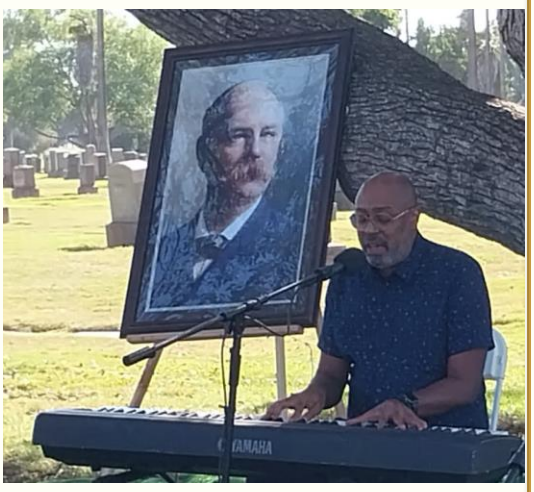
Honoring Thornton Chase, the First American Bahá'í, through prayer, music, remembrance, and fellowship at Inglewood Park Cemetery

When Music Becomes a Form of Fellowship

Music formed another important part of the commemoration.

Beneath the same sheltering branches, a guitarist, pianist, and guest vocalist shared musical offerings that brought another dimension to the afternoon's remembrance.

Among the musicians was Eric Dozier, whose work extends beyond musical performance into education, cultural understanding, racial reconciliation, and community transformation.



Dozier's broader artistic philosophy recognizes music as a means of bringing people together across differences of background and experience. His work with community choirs, young people, and educational initiatives explores how shared musical expression can cultivate understanding and inspire collective action.

That philosophy found a fitting setting at a memorial dedicated to an early believer whose own life had been shaped by a commitment to spiritual unity.

The guitar and keyboard accompanied the voices of the performers, while the guest vocalist added another layer of expression to the gathering.

The music offered participants an opportunity to experience remembrance not only through historical reflection and spoken prayer, but also through the emotional and spiritual language of song.

For an occasion centered on a life of faith, the arts served as a reminder that devotion may find expression in many forms.

Some offer prayers. Some teach. Some write. Some organize gatherings or welcome visitors. Others bring their gifts through music, theater, and creative expression.



Each contribution, offered in a spirit of service, has the potential to touch another heart.

Beyond the Program, the Bonds of Friendship

As the formal program drew to a close, the spirit of the gathering continued.

Friends approached Thornton Chase's resting place to offer prayers and reflect quietly upon his life. The polished memorial, surrounded by carefully arranged flowers and greenery, provided a peaceful setting for individual remembrance.

Elsewhere, conversations continued among those who had gathered.

Refreshments offered an opportunity to linger, reconnect with familiar faces, meet new friends, and exchange stories. Some participants renewed friendships formed over years of community activities. Others encountered one another for the first time, discovering shared interests, experiences, and connections.

There was laughter as well as reflection, lighthearted conversation alongside more thoughtful exchanges.

These seemingly ordinary moments of fellowship were not separate from the purpose of the gathering. They were part of its expression.

REMEMBRANCE & COMMUNITY LIFE

Beneath the Tree, a Legacy of Faith

Honoring Thornton Chase, the First American Bahá'í, through prayer, music, remembrance, and fellowship at Inglewood Park Cemetery





A community is strengthened not only through its formal programs, but also through the relationships that grow around them. A conversation begun beside a memorial, an introduction made over refreshments, or a shared moment of humor may become the beginning of a friendship, an opportunity for collaboration, or an unexpected source of encouragement.

The significance of such encounters may not be immediately apparent.

Yet they reflect an essential dimension of Bahá'í community life: the effort to cultivate bonds of genuine affection and unity among people whose lives might otherwise never intersect.

The Legacy We Carry Forward

More than a century has passed since Thornton Chase's earthly life came to an end.

The world has changed profoundly. The Bahá'í community he helped nurture has grown far beyond the small circle of early believers who first embraced the teachings in America.

Yet the questions raised by his example remain.

What does it mean to recognize a spiritual truth and allow it to transform the direction of one's life? What responsibilities accompany the gift of faith? And how might an individual, through steadfastness and love, contribute to a future that he or she may never personally witness?

Thornton Chase could not have known every consequence of his decision to embrace the Bahá'í Faith. Nor could he have foreseen the generations of believers who would one day gather beside his resting place, offering prayers and music in gratitude for his service.

But his life reminds us that the influence of a sincere act of faith may extend far beyond the circumstances in which it first takes place.

Perhaps that is among the most meaningful lessons of this annual remembrance.

The friends gathered beneath the tree did more than honor a figure from history. Through their prayers, their artistic contributions, their fellowship, and their shared commitment to spiritual community, they participated in the continuation of a legacy.

The young performers, the musicians, the families, the organizers, and the visitors each contributed something to an occasion whose significance lay not in grandeur, but in the spirit of remembrance and unity.

And when the afternoon ended, the memorial remained, surrounded by flowers and sheltered beneath the trees.

The gathering had concluded, but the invitation offered by Thornton Chase's example endured.

To live with sincerity. To serve with steadfastness. To recognize the light of faith in others. And to remember that the seeds planted through a single life may continue bearing fruit for generations yet to come.

COMMUNITY VOICES | REFLECTIONS FROM SERVICE

A Small Invitation, a Profound Lesson

Two doorsteps, two very different responses, and a reminder that the power of sincere service cannot always be measured by the outcome.

A true experience shared anonymously by a friend from one of our communities

From the Editor

Sometimes the most profound lessons of service emerge not from moments of confidence or apparent success, but from the very experiences that leave us questioning whether we have done enough.

The following account, generously shared by a member of our community, captures such a moment. It concerns a young person extending an invitation, an experienced friend observing, and two encounters that unfolded quite differently.

At its heart is a lesson about humility, sincerity, and the unseen possibilities that accompany even our most imperfect efforts.

We are grateful to the contributor for entrusting us with this experience and for allowing it to be shared anonymously, in the hope that others may find encouragement in its message.

In the Contributor's Own Words

As a senior who has been around the block, I usually feel I have enough experience to make a passable invitation to a wider community member to participate in a Core Activity. However, a few days ago I learned a powerful lesson about how Baha'u'llah uses us as channels for His Grace, regardless if we are skilled.

I was out with two youth, and we were taking turns extending invitations. At one house it was the turn of a young man of about 20 years old to present the invitation. He stepped up to the door and knocked. When the door opened, a woman in her 50s appeared. He stood frozen, rooted to the spot, completely speechless, for so long that the other youth and I wondered if we should step up to his side.

Then, falteringly, he began to speak. He explained that we are looking for people who are interested in building community. At his very first words, the lady of the house beamed with an immense smile. I could have sworn her heart opened up right then and there; she looked as though she wanted to reach out and hug this young man, but she didn't. She lovingly asked for more information and waited.

We all waited. And again, he falteringly explained that we are looking especially for youth around 11 - 15 years old to be part of a group who would be doing service projects in the community.

The beautiful heartfelt connection continued, and she laughed with joy while explaining that her sons are both in their 30s and have their own families.

"What a beautiful learning about how even the most humble effort can have the mightiest effect."

Later on, this young man extended an invitation at a different home. This time a young lady opened the door. I didn't hear exactly the words this young man said, but she quickly responded that no, there was no interest.

As we walked away, this young man wondered out loud, if he could have done something differently. Could he have done it better.

The other youth and I reassured him that, while there is always room to grow, it probably hadn't been about him. We reminded him of the first woman who had responded with overwhelming love, regardless of how smooth the invitation was. In fact, because it was the way it was, that's what likely evoked such a deep loving response from her. Contrasting that with the second door, it became clear that the response depends entirely on where the listener is at in their own heart.

What a beautiful learning about how even the most humble effort can have the mightiest effect.



COMMUNITY VOICES | REFLECTIONS FROM SERVICE

The Gift of an Imperfect Offering



An editorial reflection:

There is something especially moving about the young man's hesitation.

He stood at the threshold of a stranger's home, entrusted with an invitation he sincerely wished to extend, yet momentarily unable to find the words.

From the outside, it might have appeared that he was struggling to accomplish a simple task. Yet the woman who opened the door seemed to recognize something beyond his uncertainty. She responded not to the polish of his presentation, but to the spirit of the encounter.

And perhaps the most instructive part of this account is what happened afterward.

The same young man, extending another invitation, received an entirely different response.

Had he experienced only the second encounter, he might have walked away believing that his nervousness had diminished the value of his effort. Had he experienced only the first, he might have concluded that he had somehow mastered the art of invitation.

Together, the two encounters offered a deeper lesson.

We can prepare ourselves, strive to develop our capacities, approach others with courtesy and wisdom, and learn to communicate more effectively. These efforts matter. Yet we cannot determine another person's readiness, circumstances, or response.

Nor should we confuse a favorable response with proof of our own excellence, or an unfavorable response with evidence of our inadequacy.

The young man's willingness to try, his companions' encouragement, and the unexpected warmth of the first encounter all reveal something important about the process of learning through service.

Perhaps somewhere among our communities, another young person is hesitating before extending an invitation. Perhaps an adult is questioning whether they possess the knowledge or confidence to contribute. Perhaps someone has offered friendship or assistance and received little encouragement in return.

May this account remind them that their efforts need not be flawless to be meaningful.

We may never know the full influence of a conversation, an invitation, or a simple gesture of kindness. But we can continue to offer them with sincerity, learn from the experiences they bring, and trust that the worth of service is not measured solely by the response we receive.

Sometimes, what appears to be an uncertain beginning becomes the very moment through which a heart is touched.

And sometimes, the person who came to extend an invitation is the one who returns home having received the greatest gift.

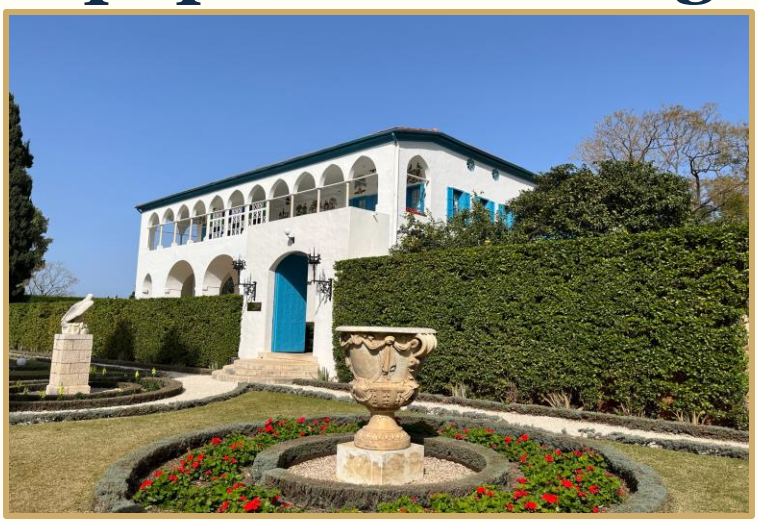
The purpose is not to become so accomplished that we never falter. It is to grow in capacity without losing the humility, sincerity, and love that give our efforts their meaning.

Threads of Light *welcomes true experiences and reflections from community life. Contributions may be shared anonymously when requested, with care taken to respect the privacy and dignity of those involved.*

FAITH IN ACTION

Part One: A Sacred Law of Love, Trust, and Spiritual Responsibility

Ḥuqúqu'lláh: The Right of God



What does it mean to offer to God a portion of what He has entrusted to us?

Among the sacred laws revealed by Bahá'u'lláh is Ḥuqúqu'lláh, meaning "The Right of God." Far more than a financial obligation, it is a divine ordinance through which the individual believer expresses devotion to God, purifies material possessions, and participates in the advancement of His Cause.

Established in the *Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, the Most Holy Book, this law occupies a distinctive place in Bahá'í life. It unites material responsibility with spiritual purpose, inviting believers to consider not only what they possess, but their relationship to the Creator and the use of resources entrusted to their care.

A Divine Law and a Spiritual Bounty

Bahá'u'lláh ordained that, when the prescribed conditions are met, nineteen percent of a believer's assessable possessions constitutes the Right of God.

In the *Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, paragraph 97, He explains that the purpose of this commandment includes the purification of possessions and the attainment of spiritual blessings.

The significance of Ḥuqúqu'lláh, however, cannot be understood through its percentage alone. The Writings make clear that God is entirely independent of human wealth. The benefit of obedience to this law returns to the believer.

Thus, what appears outwardly to be an offering of material resources is, inwardly, an opportunity to cultivate detachment, gratitude, trust, and faithfulness to God's commandments.

An Obligation Governed by Conscience

One of the most distinctive features of Ḥuqúqu'lláh is the manner in which it is observed.

Although it is a binding spiritual obligation for Bahá'ís who meet its conditions, its calculation and payment are matters of individual conscience. The law must not be enforced through demands, pressure, or solicitation.

Bahá'u'lláh emphasizes that the offering is to be made willingly, with joy and radiance.

This principle preserves the sacred character of the act. Its observance rests upon the individual's relationship with God, rather than upon external enforcement or public recognition.

The Spiritual Meaning of Material Wealth

The Bahá'í teachings do not condemn the acquisition of wealth itself. Rather, they direct attention to the attitudes with which material resources are acquired, possessed, and used.

Ḥuqúqu'lláh invites believers to examine those attitudes in the light of divine teachings.

It encourages an understanding of material resources as means that can contribute to spiritual development and the well-being of society, rather than as ends in themselves.

FROM THE WRITINGS OF BAHÁ'U'LLÁH

"If one spontaneously offereth Ḥuqúq with the utmost joy and radiance it will be acceptable, and not otherwise."

Bahá'u'lláh, Ḥuqúqu'lláh—The Right of God, extract 5

FAITH IN ACTION

Part One: A Sacred Law of Love, Trust, and Spiritual Responsibility

Ḥuqúqu'lláh: The Right of God

'Abdu'l-Bahá explains that cooperation, mutual assistance, and reciprocity are essential to human progress. In discussing Ḥuqúqu'lláh, He identifies these principles as fundamental to the institution, whose proceeds support the advancement of such purposes.

The law therefore connects the spiritual development of the individual with the collective progress of humanity.

How Is the Right of God Determined?

The law establishes a rate of nineteen percent on possessions subject to Ḥuqúqu'lláh, once the prescribed threshold, equivalent to nineteen mithqáls of gold, has been reached.

The calculation takes account of applicable expenses, debts, and exemptions. A believer's residence and necessary household furnishings are among the exempt possessions.

Ḥuqúqu'lláh is not a recurring tax on the same possessions. Once it has been paid on a particular amount, that amount is not assessed again merely because another year has passed.

The obligation is also conditional upon financial ability. Bahá'u'lláh expressly provides that those unable to meet it are excused.

Although its general principles are established, certain practical decisions concerning expenses, timing, and application are left to the judgment and conscience of the individual believer.

A Sacred Trust for the Common Good

Ḥuqúqu'lláh is distinct from voluntary contributions to the various Bahá'í Funds.

The Right of God is offered to the designated Central Authority of the Faith, presently the Universal House of Justice, which determines its disbursement.

The authoritative texts identify purposes including the advancement of the Faith, the establishment and support of its institutions, and charitable and benevolent undertakings.

In this way, the observance of a personal spiritual obligation also contributes to the material means necessary for collective endeavors.

An Invitation to Reflect

The law of Ḥuqúqu'lláh invites us to consider the relationship between material life and spiritual responsibility.

How do we understand the resources entrusted to us? How might obedience to divine commandments deepen our detachment from material possessions? And how can our use of wealth reflect a growing commitment to the well-being of others?

These questions offer a starting point for exploring a law whose spiritual significance extends far beyond the calculation of an amount.

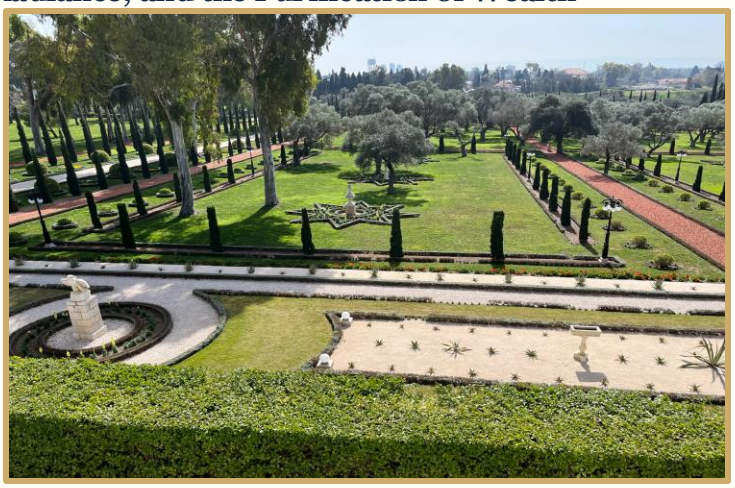
In future installments of this series, we will turn more closely to the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh and 'Abdu'l-Bahá, examine the principles governing the application of Ḥuqúqu'lláh, and consider its place in the spiritual and material progress of humanity.

This article is an introductory overview. Readers seeking guidance on the application of the law to their individual circumstances are encouraged to consult the authoritative compilation and codification and the institution of Ḥuqúqu'lláh.

Sources for Further Study

- Bahá'u'lláh, *The Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, paragraph 97; Questions and Answers, nos. 8 and 42.
- *Ḥuqúqu'lláh—The Right of God*, compilation prepared by the Research Department of the Bahá'í World Centre, amended August 2009, especially extracts 3, 5, 8, 22, 23, 33, 34, and 45.
- *A Codification of the Law of Ḥuqúqu'lláh*, Research Department of the Bahá'í World Centre, revised 2007.
- Universal House of Justice, Riḍván 1991 message to the Bahá'ís of the world.

Next in the Series: The Spirit of Giving: Joy, Radiance, and the Purification of Wealth



The Rhythm of Bahá'í Life: Month of Qudrat

Power and Purpose

The Thirteenth Month of the Bahá'í Calendar | ***November 4 to 22, 2026 | 183 B.E.***

QUDRAT • POWER



The Power That Transforms

What is true power? Is it found in authority, influence, or the ability to command? Or might its highest expression be found in something less visible, yet infinitely more enduring: the power to unite hearts, overcome prejudice, show compassion, and serve humanity?

As we enter **Qudrat**, the thirteenth month of the Bahá'í calendar, we are invited to reflect upon the divine attribute of **Power** and how its influence can find expression in our lives.

The Badí' calendar, introduced by the Báb and confirmed and adopted by Bahá'u'lláh, consists of nineteen months of nineteen days each, with additional intercalary days. Each month bears the name of an attribute of God, offering a recurring opportunity for spiritual reflection.

Qudrat, meaning ***Power***, calls our attention to the distinction between worldly power and divine power.

In the Bahá'í Writings, God is described as the ultimate source of power, upon Whom all creation depends. The transformative influence of divine Revelation is likewise reflected in its capacity to unite hearts, awaken spiritual understanding, and inspire humanity toward love and fellowship.

For us, reflecting on **Qudrat** can mean considering how we exercise the capacities entrusted to us. Do our words encourage or discourage? Does our influence bring people together or drive them apart? Do we use our abilities for personal recognition, or place them in service to others?

The strength to forgive when wounded, to remain steadfast amid difficulties, to speak with kindness when confronted by anger, or to persevere in service when results are not immediately visible can each become an expression of spiritual strength.

Perhaps one of the most meaningful ways to observe this month is to remember that the **power** to contribute to the betterment of the world need not begin with grand undertakings. It may begin with a single act of generosity, a sincere conversation, a prayer offered for another, or a hand extended in friendship.

As we welcome **Qudrat**, may we reflect upon the divine source of all power and strive to make our own actions instruments of unity, compassion, and service.

A Reflection for the Month

Where in my life can I replace the desire to prevail with the determination to serve? How might I use the influence I possess to strengthen another soul?

Also during Qudrat: The Bahá'í community commemorates the Birth of the Báb on November 10 and the Birth of Bahá'u'lláh on November 11, 2026.

> ***"All existence is dependent upon Him, and from Him is derived the source of the sustenance of all things."***
>
> ***BAHÁ'U'LLÁH — GLEANINGS, LXXXIV***

A WORD FOR THE HEART

Read • Reflect • Live

A recurring monthly exploration of one Hidden Word of Bahá'u'lláh

From the Persian

In the Name of the Lord of Utterance, the Mighty.

1 O YE PEOPLE THAT HAVE MINDS TO KNOW AND EARS TO HEAR!

The first call of the Beloved is this: O mystic nightingale! Abide not but in the rose garden of the spirit. O messenger of the Solomon of love! Seek thou no shelter except in the Sheba of the well-beloved, and O immortal phoenix! dwell not save on the mount of faithfulness. Therein is thy habitation, if on the wings of thy soul thou soarest to the realm of the infinite and seekest to attain thy goal.



Where Does the Soul Find Its Home?

In the first of the Persian Hidden Words, Bahá'u'lláh addresses those who possess the capacity to know and the willingness to hear. His words unfold through three exquisite images: the mystic nightingale, the messenger of Solomon, and the immortal phoenix. Each is directed toward a place of belonging: the rose garden of the spirit, the Sheba of the well-beloved, and the mount of faithfulness.

The nightingale, so often associated in Persian poetry with longing for the rose, is called to make its dwelling in the garden of the spirit. The messenger of Solomon is instructed to seek refuge only in the Sheba of the beloved. The phoenix, a symbol often associated with immortality and renewal, is directed toward the mount of faithfulness.

These images invite us to consider where we seek our own spiritual refuge. Do we make our home in the passing comforts of the material world, in the approval of others, or in the enduring qualities of love, faithfulness, and nearness to God?

There is something particularly tender in the instruction to abide, seek shelter, and dwell. The passage does not merely call the soul to visit these spiritual realities occasionally. It invites the soul to make them its habitation, its place of belonging.

And yet, the concluding words introduce movement and aspiration. The soul must soar on its own wings toward the realm of the infinite. Spiritual growth calls for more than admiration of divine teachings. It asks us to orient our lives toward them, to cultivate the qualities they reveal, and to persevere in seeking the Beloved.

Perhaps the most profound question is not simply where we wish to go spiritually, but where we have already chosen to dwell through our thoughts, attachments, decisions, and actions.

The first Persian Hidden Word thus offers a beautiful beginning to our journey through this sacred collection: an invitation to recognize the true home of the soul and to direct our lives toward it.

A Moment for Reflection

Read the Hidden Word once more, slowly, allowing each image to rest upon your heart.

Where does my soul seek shelter?

When faced with uncertainty, disappointment, or difficulty, do I turn toward the enduring refuge of faith, prayer, and love, or do I seek security in things that cannot truly sustain me?

What might it mean, in my own circumstances, to dwell upon the mount of faithfulness?

Putting the Teaching into Practice

During this Bahá'í month, choose one deliberate act that strengthens your spiritual dwelling place. Perhaps it is remaining faithful to a commitment when doing so is difficult, responding with kindness when patience is tested, dedicating time to prayer amid competing demands, or extending friendship to someone who feels forgotten.

At the next Feast, consider what this experience taught you. Did your understanding of faithfulness deepen? Did you discover a new source of spiritual strength?

The invitation is to carry the wisdom of the Hidden Word into the way we live.

Courage: The Strength to Take the First Step

Sometimes the smallest act of bravery opens the door to the greatest possibilities.

Courage is often associated with extraordinary acts: standing against injustice, facing danger, or overcoming seemingly impossible obstacles. Yet some of its most meaningful expressions are found in the quiet moments of everyday life.

It takes courage to acknowledge a mistake, to speak truthfully when silence would be easier, to offer friendship despite the possibility of rejection, or to begin something worthwhile without knowing whether it will succeed.

Courage does not require us to feel fearless. Rather, it invites us to recognize our fears without allowing them to determine our actions.

This virtue is especially meaningful in the life of a community. Every new friendship begins with someone reaching out. Every act of service begins with someone deciding to help. Every effort to build understanding requires a willingness to listen, learn, and sometimes reconsider what we believe we know.

In this inaugural issue, we encounter courage in the experience of a young man who, despite his uncertainty, stepped forward to invite a stranger to participate in community life. His words were hesitant, but his sincerity was unmistakable. The experience reminds us that the worth of an effort cannot always be measured by its immediate result.

Courage may be expressed through great sacrifice, but it may also begin with a simple invitation, a kind word, an honest conversation, or a willingness to try again.

Perhaps the question is not whether we feel courageous, but what good we might accomplish if we take the next step anyway.

Leo the Lion's Little Lesson

The Brave Little Roar

Leo was a young lion with a very small roar.

Whenever the other animals gathered, Leo wanted to join their conversations and games. But every time he thought about speaking, his paws grew nervous and his little roar seemed to disappear.

"What if they don't want me there?" he wondered.

One morning, Leo noticed a young rabbit sitting alone beneath a tree.

He wanted to say hello, but he felt that familiar flutter in his tummy.

Then Leo remembered something important: he did not need the loudest roar in the forest to offer someone kindness.

So he walked over and whispered, "Would you like to play?"

The rabbit smiled.

"I was hoping someone would ask!"



And just like that, Leo discovered something wonderful.

Being brave did not mean having a mighty roar. Sometimes it meant finding the courage to use his gentle voice.

Courage: The Strength to Take the First Step

Sometimes the smallest act of bravery opens the door to the greatest possibilities.



Practicing Courage Together

For our younger readers: Think of one kind thing you would like to do but feel a little nervous about. Perhaps introducing yourself to someone new, asking a question, or trying something unfamiliar. What small first step could you take?

For youth and adults: Consider a situation in which fear of rejection, embarrassment, or uncertainty has kept you from acting. Is there one thoughtful step you could take toward what you believe is right?

For families and communities: Share an experience when someone showed quiet courage. What did their example teach you?

A Small Challenge for the Month

Before the next Feast, choose one act of courage rooted in kindness, truthfulness, or service.

It need not be grand. It need only be sincere.

Every great journey begins with a first step. Sometimes that first step is the bravest part.

About this series

Virtues in Action is a recurring feature of ***Threads of Light***, exploring spiritual and moral qualities through reflection, storytelling, and practical application for readers of all ages.

Inspired in part by the educational approach of The Virtues Project, this independently written series invites children, youth, and adults to discover how virtues can be cultivated and expressed in everyday life.

About Leo the Lion

Leo the Lion is an original character created for ***Threads of Light*** to help readers of all ages explore spiritual virtues through storytelling. His adventures are fictional illustrations of everyday lessons in character, kindness, and service. They are not quotations or stories from the Bahá'í Sacred Writings or The Virtues Project.

Help Leo Discover His Next Virtue!

What virtue would you like Leo to explore next? Perhaps kindness, patience, truthfulness, generosity, or perseverance?

We welcome suggestions from children, youth, families, and friends of all ages. Share a virtue that has helped you through a challenge or inspired an act of service.

Your suggestion may inspire one of Leo's future adventures!

Share your ideas:
threadsoflightnews@gmail.com

THE NINE YEAR PLAN | PART ONE

Building a Better World, One Community at a Time

Understanding the vision of the Nine Year Plan and the society-building power of faith expressed through service.

A Vision That Extends Beyond Our Own Generation

What does it mean to contribute to the betterment of the world?

For some, the question may evoke visions of extraordinary achievements, sweeping social reforms, or efforts undertaken by institutions and organizations with considerable resources.

Yet the transformation of society also begins in places far more familiar: within our homes, among our neighbors, in the education of children, through friendships that overcome prejudice, and in the quiet determination of individuals who choose to serve.

These seemingly modest efforts are part of a much greater undertaking.

At Riḍván 2026, the worldwide Bahá'í community entered the second phase of the Nine Year Plan, building upon the experience and capacities developed during its opening four years. It will continue until Riḍván 2031. It forms the first major stage of a twenty-five-year series of Plans extending to Riḍván 2046.

At the heart of this undertaking is an extraordinary vision: the progressive release of the society-building power of the Faith of Bahá'u'lláh.

What Is the Society Building Power of the Faith?

The Universal House of Justice explains that the teachings of Bahá'u'lláh provide a foundation for communities to learn how to contribute to humanity's spiritual and material progress.

This involves more than increasing participation in religious activities. It calls for the development of capacities, relationships, institutions, and patterns of collective life through which people can work together for the common good.

The Plan embraces three interconnected areas of endeavor: strengthening vibrant and outward-looking communities, contributing to social and economic development, and participating in the discourses that influence society.

These efforts are not isolated pursuits. They reinforce one another as individuals and communities learn to translate spiritual principles into practical action.

The Role of Every Individual

One of the most encouraging aspects of the Plan is that meaningful participation is not reserved for those with exceptional knowledge, experience, or resources.

A young person helping to organize a junior youth group, a family welcoming neighbors to a devotional gathering, a teacher nurturing the spiritual qualities of children, or a friend accompanying someone who wishes to begin serving may each contribute to a growing pattern of community life.

No single effort accomplishes the work of transformation. But through sustained participation, consultation, reflection, and learning, individual contributions can become part of something much greater.

Learning Together, Growing Together



The Nine Year Plan places particular emphasis on the development of capacity at the level of the individual, the community, and the institutions of the Faith.

Each has a distinctive role. Each depends upon the others. As their relationships strengthen, communities become increasingly capable of identifying needs, responding to challenges, welcoming participation, and contributing to the well-being of the wider population.

Progress is therefore not measured simply by the number of activities undertaken. It also involves the quality of relationships, the capacities developed, the participation encouraged, and the ability to learn from experience.

From Vision to Everyday Action

The experiences shared throughout this inaugural issue offer glimpses of principles that are relevant to the Plan.

A young person finds the courage to extend an invitation despite uncertainty. Friends gather in consultation and fellowship. Books are shared so that knowledge and spiritual resources may reach new readers.

THE NINE YEAR PLAN | PART ONE

Building a Better World, One Community at a Time

Understanding the vision of the Nine Year Plan and the society-building power of faith expressed through service.

These experiences are not presented as formal assessments of progress under the Plan. Rather, they illustrate qualities such as initiative, generosity, cooperation, courage, and a willingness to learn. Such qualities can help sustain community building efforts.

The vision before us is vast, but participation need not begin with something grand.

It may begin with a conversation, an invitation, a willingness to accompany another person, or a simple question:

What can I do, in my own circumstances, to contribute to the betterment of my community?

Perhaps the most hopeful realization is that we need not wait for the world to change before beginning this work.

We can begin where we are, with those around us, learning together as we go.

A Question for Reflection

What capacity could I develop, or what relationship could I strengthen, that would help me contribute more effectively to the well-being of my community?

Coming Next — Part Two: The Individual, the Community, and the Institutions: Three Protagonists of the Plan.

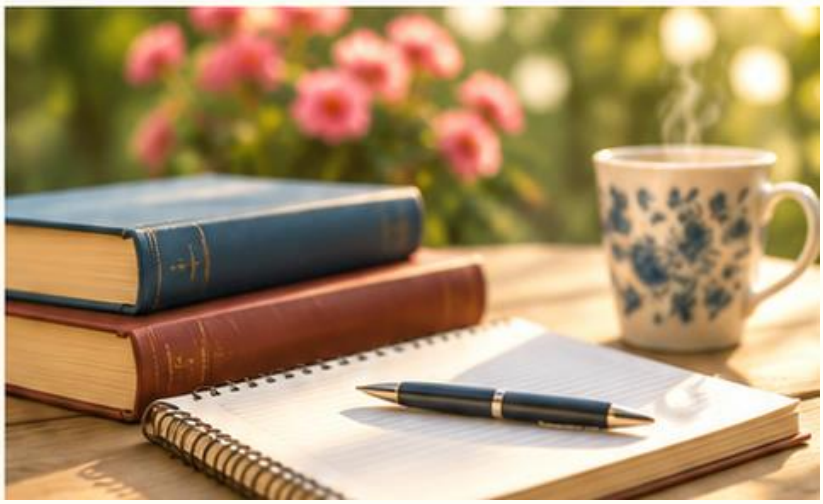
Authoritative Sources

- Universal House of Justice, message dated December 30, 2021, to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors.
- Universal House of Justice, Riḍván 2022 message to the Bahá'ís of the World.



Questions for Personal Reflection

- In my own circumstances, what is one concrete way I can contribute to the betterment of my community?
- How can I learn, alongside others, to translate my talents, interests, and experience into meaningful service?



KEEP THE LIGHT MOVING

Your Story Matters

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Inaugural issue • November 4, 2026

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